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OCR GCSE Geography B (J384) — Paper 2: People and Society · Topic 7: UK in the 21st Century

2.3 UK in the 21st Century

1. UK Population Distribution and Major Cities

- The UK has a population of about **69 million**, and over **80%** live in urban areas.
- Population is **unevenly distributed**. The highest densities are in the South East (especially Greater London, about 5,700 people per km²), the Midlands conurbations, the North West (Manchester, Liverpool), West Yorkshire and central Scotland.
- The lowest densities are in upland and remote areas such as the Scottish Highlands (under 10 people per km²), mid-Wales and the Pennines, where relief is steep, the climate is harsh and there are fewer jobs.
- Major cities grew around coalfields, ports and industry during the Industrial Revolution (Manchester, Birmingham, Glasgow, Newcastle), while London grew as the capital, port and centre of trade and finance.

2. The UK's Population in the 21st Century

- **Population:** about 69 million in 2023, up from 59 million in 2001. Growth has come from natural increase and, mainly, net international migration.
- **Ageing population:** over 18% of people are aged 65 or over, and the number aged 85+ is rising fastest. Causes: falling birth rates (fertility about 1.4–1.5 children per woman) and longer life expectancy.
- **Impacts of ageing:** more pressure on the NHS, social care and pensions; fewer workers paying taxes per retired person; but older people also contribute through volunteering, childcare and spending (the "grey pound").
- The UK population pyramid has a narrowing base and a widening top — typical of stage 4/5 of the Demographic Transition Model.

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3. Rural and Urban Contrasts in the UK

- **Core regions** (London and the South East, major cities) have high population density, high employment and strong economies. **Peripheral regions** (Scottish Highlands, rural Wales, Cornwall) have lower densities, ageing populations and fewer jobs.
- Population density ranges from over 5,000 people per km² in Greater London to under 10 people per km² in the Highlands.
- Rural areas close to cities ("accessible rural") are growing through counter-urbanisation; remote rural areas often decline as young people leave.

4. The UK's Changing Economy and Population

Sector	Change
Primary	Under 2% of jobs (farming, fishing, mining) — the last deep coal mine closed in 2015
Secondary	Manufacturing fell from around 30% of jobs in the 1970s to under 8% today (deindustrialisation)
Tertiary	Over 80% of jobs — retail, health, education, finance, tourism
Quaternary	A growing share — research, IT, biotechnology, creative industries

- **Government policy** has shaped this change: privatisation in the 1980s, investment in regeneration, enterprise zones and science parks.
- **Migration:** net international migration has been a major part of UK population growth. Migrants fill skills and labour shortages (e.g. in the NHS, construction and agriculture) and are concentrated in cities, especially London.
- **Ageing population:** over 18% of people are aged 65 or over, increasing demand for health and social care.

5. Economic Futures in the UK — Causes of Change

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Cause	Explanation
Deindustrialisation	The decline of traditional industries such as coal mining, steel, shipbuilding and textiles from the 1960s onwards. Coal mining employed around a million people in the 1920s; by 2015 the last deep coal mine (Kellingley) had closed. Causes: cheaper imports, exhaustion of resources, mechanisation.
Globalisation	Manufacturing moved to countries with lower labour costs (the global shift); the UK specialised in services, finance and high-tech industries instead.
Government policies	Privatisation and the closure of state-owned industries in the 1980s; later investment in regeneration, enterprise zones, the Northern Powerhouse and "levelling up". Membership and then departure from the EU (2020) changed trade relationships.

6. The UK's Post-Industrial Economy

Post-industrial economy — an economy in which most people work in the tertiary (services) and quaternary (knowledge, research and IT) sectors rather than in manufacturing. Over 80% of UK jobs are now in services.

- **Information technology:** software, digital and tech companies — London's "Tech City" (Shoreditch), Manchester, Cambridge.
- **Service industries:** retail, tourism, health, education.
- **Finance:** the City of London and Canary Wharf, Edinburgh and Leeds — financial services contribute around 8–9% of UK economic output.
- **Research:** universities and research institutes, pharmaceutical and biotechnology firms.

Science and business parks — Cambridge Science Park

- Founded by Trinity College in 1970 — the oldest science park in the UK. It is home to over 100 companies employing about 7,000 people, mainly in biotechnology, IT and research.
- Location factors: links with Cambridge University research and graduates; access to the M11 and A14 and to Stansted airport; an attractive environment.

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- It is part of "Silicon Fen", the cluster of high-tech firms around Cambridge.

Environmental impact of industry — Torr Quarry, Somerset

- Torr Quarry, near Frome, is one of the UK's largest limestone quarries, supplying crushed rock for roads and construction.
- **Impacts:** visual scarring, noise, dust and heavy lorry traffic; loss of habitats.
- **Making it more sustainable:** about 75% of the stone leaves by rail rather than road; screening banks and tree planting hide the quarry; the quarry floor is being restored as lakes and wildlife habitats; blasting is limited to set times.

7. The North–South Divide

- The UK has an economic divide between the more prosperous **South East** (especially London) and parts of the **North, Midlands, Wales and Northern Ireland**, which were hit harder by deindustrialisation.
- Differences include wages, house prices, life expectancy, educational results and unemployment. London's output per head is around 1.7 times the UK average.

Strategies to resolve regional differences

- **Northern Powerhouse** (from 2014) — investment in transport, science and innovation in northern cities.
- **Devolution** — powers and budgets given to elected mayors (e.g. Greater Manchester, West Midlands) and to Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland.
- **Enterprise zones and freeports** — tax breaks and simpler planning to attract businesses to struggling areas.
- **Levelling up funds** — money for town centres, transport and regeneration in poorer areas; moving some government jobs out of London (e.g. Treasury campus in Darlington).

8. Counterurbanisation and the Impact of COVID-19

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Counterurbanisation: The movement of people **away from large urban areas** to smaller towns, villages, or rural areas. The opposite of urbanisation. In the UK, counterurbanisation has occurred since the 1970s, driven by improved transport, rising urban house prices, remote working technology, and a desire for a different quality of life.

Causes of Counterurbanisation

Cause	Detail
Rising urban house prices	Families are priced out of cities (especially London) and move to commuter towns or more affordable regions. London's average house price (£500,000+) drives out young families who can buy a larger home for £200,000 in Lincolnshire or South Wales.
Improved transport links	High-speed rail (e.g. services from London to Bristol in about 1h30; Leeds about 2h15) and motorway networks make living further from the workplace viable. Commuting from York, Peterborough, or Swindon to London is feasible.
Remote and hybrid working	Pre-COVID, remote working was unusual. Post-COVID (especially post-2020), millions of knowledge workers can work from home part or all of the week — removing the need to live close to a city centre office.
Quality of life motivations	Desire for larger homes, gardens, access to countryside, lower crime rates, better schools, quieter environments — especially among families with children
Retirement migration	Retirees move away from cities towards coastal areas (Devon, Dorset, Norfolk, Cornwall) or rural areas — this has been a long-term trend; some villages in rural England have >30% of population aged 65+

COVID-19 and Counterurbanisation — The "Race for Space"

The COVID-19 pandemic (2020–2021) significantly accelerated counterurbanisation trends. Estate agents coined the term **"race for space"** to describe the surge in demand for rural and small-town properties. Key data:

- **House price growth:** During 2020–2022, rural and coastal property prices grew faster than urban prices for the first time in decades. Cornwall and Wales saw **house price growth well above the**

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national average in 2020–22.

- **City exodus:** An early 2021 estimate suggested London's population had fallen by ~700,000, although later ONS and Census 2021 data showed the fall was much smaller. Many moved to Kent, Essex, Hertfordshire, and the Home Counties.
- **Rural broadband demand:** The pandemic exposed inadequate rural internet infrastructure; demand for full-fibre broadband in rural areas surged as home-working became standard. Government committed £5bn to Project Gigabit (2021) to improve rural connectivity.
- **Second home crisis:** In Cornwall, Devon, and the Welsh countryside, the influx of urban buyers (both permanent movers and second-home buyers) caused house prices to rise beyond the reach of local workers — teachers, nurses, agricultural workers — who earn local wages. In some Cornish villages, second homes now constitute >50% of properties. Wales allowed councils to charge council tax premiums of up to 300% on second homes (from 2023) to deter this.
- **Partial reversal:** By 2023–24, as offices reopened and hybrid working settled into 2–3 days/week, some counterurbanisation reversed. Many who had moved to the countryside found rural isolation challenging or that commuting costs became prohibitive as fuel and rail fares rose. City rental prices rose sharply as demand returned.

Effects of Counterurbanisation on Rural Areas

Effect	Detail
Rising house prices	Incoming urban buyers (with higher incomes and equity from city homes) outbid local people; younger local residents cannot afford to buy in the area they grew up
Village services	New affluent residents support some services (gastropubs, artisan food shops) but may not use local schools, post offices, or buses — leading to selective closure of "everyday" services
Cultural change	The character of rural communities changes — traditional farming communities give way to commuter and retiree populations; traditional skills and occupations decline

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Traffic and environmental pressure	More car commuters on rural roads; pressure on National Parks and Areas of Outstanding Natural Beauty; erosion of footpaths; damage to habitats
Some positive effects	Demographic boost to declining rural areas; new spending in local economies; renovation of derelict properties; new business activity

Exam Tip — Counterurbanisation: Link causes to COVID-19 evidence if the question allows it. The key fact is that the pandemic showed remote working could happen at scale, accelerating a pre-existing trend. However, the long-term picture is complex — rural areas gain population but lose housing affordability; cities lose population in the short term but rents and prices recover as demand returns. Always evaluate: counterurbanisation has both winners (urban movers seeking space) and losers (rural locals priced out of housing).

9. The UK's Culture and Media

- **Multicultural society:** migration from the Commonwealth (Caribbean, South Asia, Africa), the EU and elsewhere has made the UK culturally diverse — in food, music, festivals, religion and language.
- **Media:** UK media such as the BBC (World Service, international news), UK film and TV (James Bond, Harry Potter, Doctor Who), music and the Premier League spread British culture around the world.
- **Global culture in the UK:** globalisation means UK culture is also shaped by American film and music, international food and global social media.
- The media influence how places are perceived — e.g. negative coverage of some inner-city areas or positive coverage of regenerated areas.

10. The UK's Role in the Wider World

Role	Examples
Political	Permanent member of the UN Security Council; member of the G7, G20, NATO and the Commonwealth (56 countries)

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Economic	One of the world's largest economies; London a global financial centre; left the EU in 2020 and joined the CPTPP trade bloc in 2024
Conflict and peacekeeping	Military role in NATO; peacekeeping and support for Ukraine; aid to countries affected by conflict
Global issues	Hosted COP26 in Glasgow (2021); legally committed to net zero by 2050; overseas aid budget (cut from 0.7% to 0.5% of GNI in 2021)

11. The UK's Place in the Wider World

- **Trade:** major trading partners include the EU (still the largest overall), the USA and China. Since leaving the EU, the UK has signed new trade deals (e.g. with Australia and New Zealand) and joined the CPTPP trade bloc (2024).
- **Culture:** a global influence through the English language, music, film, sport (the Premier League is watched worldwide) and the BBC.
- **Transport:** Heathrow is a global hub; the Channel Tunnel links the UK to mainland Europe.
- **Electronic communication:** undersea cables connect the UK to North America and Europe, making London a key centre for global data and finance.
- **The Commonwealth and international organisations:** the UK is a member of the Commonwealth (56 countries), the G7, G20, NATO and a permanent member of the UN Security Council.

Exam Tip: Questions on the UK economy often ask you to "use a named example" — Cambridge Science Park, Torr Quarry, South Cambridgeshire and the Outer Hebrides give you specific, memorable evidence to quote.

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